Pre-mortem

Imagine the work has already failed, explain why, then act now to prevent the most likely causes.

Run a Project · Inspired by Gary Klein's Pre-mortem · Prospective Hindsight · Risks Before They Happen

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

LEGEND

- Pink Sticky = Why it failed
- Dot = Vote (3 per person)

1 The Scenario

READ IT ALOUD · SPEAK AS IF IT HAS ALREADY HAPPENED

It's 1 October *and this has failed badly. What went wrong?*

Project, plan or release: the staples subscriptions pilot

Failure looks like: customers cancel, Finance stops it, and the team is worn out

2 Why It Failed

SILENT WRITING FIRST · ONE REASON PER STICKY

- Everyone writes alone for 5 minutes, in the past tense: "We lost our key supplier"
- Think wide: people, tech, customers, money, dependencies, decisions

Customers

- Customers forgot they'd subscribed, then complained ●●●●
- Felt pricier than one-off orders ●

Payments & tech

- Repeat billing failed on expired cards ●●●●●
- Wrong substitutes from stock data ●●

Operations

- Pickers couldn't spot subscription items ●
- Adding items by hand didn't scale ●●●

Us

- We launched to everyone before the pilot ended ●●
- Nobody owned it while Priya was away ●●

3 Top Risks

AFTER DOT VOTING

#	REASON	LIKELY	IMPACT	VOTES
1	Repeat billing fails	Med	High	5
2	Customers forget, then complain	High	Med	4
3	Manual work doesn't scale	High	Med	3
4	Launch before we've learned	Med	High	2

4 Prevent or Detect

FOR EACH TOP RISK

TOP RISK	WE'LL PREVENT IT BY…	EARLY WARNING SIGN	OWNER
Repeat billing fails	Spike it with Payments, including expired cards	Over 1% of charges fail	Tom
Customers forget	Reminder email 2 days before each delivery	Complaints say "didn't know"	Mei
Manual work doesn't scale	Cap at 50; automate before growing	Over 2 hours a day adding items	Priya
Launch before learning	Go / no-go on 6 June, with the data	Pressure to set a launch date	Priya

5 Next Steps

- [x] Top risks added to the RAID Log
- [x] Prevention actions added to the backlog
- [x] Warning signs visible on the team board
- [ ] Plan or scope changed where needed
- [ ] Re-run before the next big milestone

Review these risks on: 6 June, at the go / no-go

"It's six months from now and this has failed. What happened?"

"Which of these are we quietly hoping won't happen?"

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